

NINE

EVERYONE ACCORDING TO HIS WAYS¹

If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted?
and if thou doest not well, sin coucheth at the
door: and unto thee is its desire, but thou
shouldest rule over it.²

The Biblical outlook with its strong sense of personal religion involves personal responsibility for actions performed; and personal responsibility, which is also responsibility to a person, leads in its turn to the conception of forgiveness and the saving value of contrition.

A tribal sense of communal sin is often praised nowadays but in practice it means the condoning of anonymous public cruelty. Communities, like committees, have no conscience.

Joseph, being seventeen years old, was feeding the flock with his brethren; and he was a lad with the sons of Bilhah, and with the sons of Zilpah, his father's wives: and Joseph brought the evil report of them unto their father.

Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age: and he made him a coat of many colours. And his brethren saw that their father loved him more than all his brethren; and they hated him, and could not speak peaceably unto him.

And Joseph dreamed a dream, and he told it to his brethren: and they hated him yet the more. . . .

And his brethren went to feed their father's flock in

¹Ezek. 18: 30.

²Gen. 4: 7 (M).

Shechem. And Israel said unto Joseph, Do not thy brethren feed the flock in Shechem? come, and I will send thee unto them. And he said to him, Here am I. And he said unto him, Go now, see whether it be well with thy brethren, and well with the flock; and bring me word again. So he sent him out of the vale of Hebron, and he came to Shechem. And a certain man found him, and, behold, he was wandering in the field: and the man asked him, saying, What seekest thou? And he said, I seek my brethren: tell me, I pray thee, where they are feeding the flock. And the man said, They are departed hence: for I heard them say, Let us go to Dothan. And Joseph went after his brethren, and found them in Dothan.

And they saw him afar off, and before he came near unto them, they conspired against him to slay him. And they said one to another, Behold, this dreamer cometh. Come now therefore, and let us slay him, and cast him into one of the pits, and we will say, An evil beast hath devoured him: and we shall see what will become of his dreams.

And Reuben heard it, and delivered him out of their hand; and said, Let us not take his life. And Reuben said unto them, Shed no blood; cast him into this pit that is in the wilderness, but lay no hand upon him: that he might deliver him out of their hand, to restore him to his father.

And it came to pass, when Joseph was come unto his brethren, that they stript Joseph of his coat, the coat of many colours that was on him; and they took him, and cast him into the pit. . . .

And Joseph was the governor over the land; he it was that sold to all the people of the land: and Joseph's brethren came, and bowed down themselves to him with their faces to the earth. And Joseph saw his

brethren, and he knew them, but made himself strange unto them, and spake roughly with them; and he said unto them, Whence come ye? And they said, From the land of Canaan to buy food. And Joseph knew his brethren, but they knew not him.

And Joseph remembered the dreams which he dreamed of them, and said unto them, Ye are spies; to see the nakedness of the land ye are come. . . . If ye be true men, let one of your brethren be bound in your prison house: but go ye, carry corn for the famine of your houses; and bring your youngest brother unto me; so shall your words be verified, and ye shall not die. And they did so.

And they said one to another, We are verily guilty concerning our brother, in that we saw the distress of his soul, when he besought us, and we would not hear; therefore is this distress come upon us.

And Reuben answered them, saying, Spake I not unto you, saying, Do not sin against the child; and ye would not hear? therefore also, behold, his blood is required.¹

And surely your blood, the blood of your lives, will I require; at the hand of every beast will I require it: and at the hand of man, even at the hand of every man's brother, will I require the life of man.

Whoso sheddeth man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed: for in the image of God made he man.²

He that smiteth a man, so that he die, shall surely be put to death.

And if a man lie not in wait, but God deliver him into his hand; then will I appoint thee a place whither he shall flee.

¹Gen. 37: 2-5, 12-24; 42: 6-9, 19-22.

²Gen. 9: 5-6.

And if a man come presumptuously upon his neighbour, to slay him with guile; thou shalt take him from mine altar, that he may die.¹

And he that smiteth any man mortally shall surely be put to death; and he that smiteth a beast mortally shall make it good: life for life.²

Woe unto them that join house to house, that lay field to field, till there be no room, and ye be made to dwell alone in the midst of the land! In mine ears saith the Lord of hosts, Of a truth many houses shall be desolate, even great and fair, without inhabitant.³

Let them be before the Lord continually,
That he may cut off the memory of them from the earth.

Because that he [they] remembered not to show mercy,
But persecuted the poor and needy man,
And the broken in heart, to slay them.⁴

For he hath brought down them that dwell on high,
the lofty city; he layeth it low, he layeth it low even to the ground; he bringeth it even to the dust.

The foot shall tread it down; even the feet of the poor,
and the steps of the needy.⁵

Because thou hast spoiled many nations, all the remnant of the peoples shall spoil thee; because of men's blood, and for the violence done to the land, to the city and to all that dwell therein.⁶

The violence done to Lebanon shall cover thee, and the destruction of the beasts, which made them afraid.⁷

¹Exod. 21: 12-14.
²Lev. 24: 17-18.

³Isa. 5: 8-9.
⁴Ps. 109: 15-16.

⁵Isa. 26: 5-6.
⁶Hab. 2: 8.

⁷Hab. 2: 17.

O God, the God of the spirits of all flesh, shall one man sin, and wilt thou be wroth with all the congregation?¹

Lo, I have sinned, and I have done perversely: but these sheep, what have they done?²

Thou seekest to destroy a city and a mother in Israel: why wilt thou swallow up the inheritance of the Lord?

And Joab answered and said, Far be it, far be it from me, that I should swallow up or destroy. The matter is not so: but a man of the hill country of Ephraim, Sheba the son of Bichri by name, hath lifted up his hand against the king, even against David: deliver him only, and I will depart from the city.

And the woman said unto Joab, Behold, his head shall be thrown to thee over the wall. Then the woman went unto all the people in her wisdom. And they cut off the head of Sheba the son of Bichri, and threw it out to Joab. And he blew the trumpet, and they were dispersed from the city, every man to his tent.³

And it came to pass on the morrow, that Moses said unto the people, Ye have sinned a great sin: and now I will go up unto the Lord; peradventure I shall make atonement for your sin.

And Moses returned unto the Lord, and said, Oh, this people have sinned a great sin, and have made gods of gold. Yet now, if thou wilt forgive their sin—; and if not, blot me, I pray thee, out of thy book which thou hast written.

And the Lord said unto Moses, Whosoever hath sinned against me, him will I blot out of my book.⁴

¹Num. 16: 22.

²2 Sam. 24: 17.

³2 Sam. 20: 19-22.

⁴Exod. 32: 30-33.

Son of man, when a land sinneth against me by committing a trespass, and I stretch out mine hand upon it, and break the staff of the bread thereof, and send famine upon it, and cut off from it man and beast; though these three men, Noah, Daniel, and Job, were in it, they should deliver but their own souls by their righteousness, saith the Lord God.

If I cause noisome beasts to pass through the land, and they spoil it, so that it be desolate, that no man may pass through because of the beasts; though these three men were in it, as I live, saith the Lord God, they shall deliver neither sons nor daughters; they only shall be delivered, but the land shall be desolate.

Or if I bring a sword upon that land, and say, Sword, go through the land; so that I cut off from it man and beast; though these three men were in it, as I live, saith the Lord God, they shall deliver neither sons nor daughters, but they only shall be delivered themselves.

Or if I send a pestilence into that land, and pour out my fury upon it in blood, to cut off from it man and beast: though Noah, Daniel, and Job, were in it, as I live, saith the Lord God, they shall deliver neither son nor daughter; they shall but deliver their own souls by their righteousness.¹

What mean ye, that ye use this proverb concerning the land of Israel, saying, The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge? As I live, saith the Lord God, ye shall not have occasion any more to use this proverb in Israel.

Behold, all souls are mine; as the soul of the father, so also the soul of the son is mine: the soul that sinneth, it shall die.²

¹Ezek. 14: 13-20.

²Ezek. 18: 2-4.

The fathers shall not be put to death for the children, neither shall the children be put to death for the fathers: every man shall be put to death for his own sin.¹

In those days they shall say no more, The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge. But every one shall die for his own iniquity: every man that eateth the sour grapes, his teeth shall be set on edge.²

And thou, son of man, say unto the house of Israel: Thus ye speak, saying, Our transgressions and our sins are upon us, and we pine away in them; how then should we live? Say unto them, As I live, saith the Lord God, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; but that the wicked turn from his way and live: turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, O house of Israel?

And thou, son of man, say unto the children of thy people, The righteousness of the righteous shall not deliver him in the day of his transgression; and as for the wickedness of the wicked, he shall not fall thereby in the day that he turneth from his wickedness: neither shall he that is righteous be able to live thereby in the day that he sinneth.

When I say to the righteous, that he shall surely live; if he trust to his righteousness, and commit iniquity, none of his righteous deeds shall be remembered; but in his iniquity that he hath committed, therein shall he die. Again, when I say unto the wicked, Thou shalt surely die; if he turn from his sin, and do that which is lawful and right; if the wicked restore the pledge, give again that he had taken by robbery, walk in the statutes of life, committing no iniquity; he shall surely live, he shall not die.

¹Deut. 24: 16.

²Jer. 31: 29-30.

None of his sins that he hath committed shall be remembered against him: he hath done that which is lawful and right; he shall surely live.¹

Therefore I will judge you, O house of Israel, every one according to his ways, saith the Lord God.

Return ye, and turn yourselves from all your transgressions; so iniquity shall not be your ruin. Cast away from you all your transgressions, wherein ye have transgressed; and make you a new heart and a new spirit: for why will ye die, O house of Israel?

For I have no pleasure in the death of him that dieth, saith the Lord God: wherefore turn yourselves, and live.²

If one man sin against another, God shall judge him: but if a man sin against the Lord, who shall intreat for him?³

Before the Lord shall ye be clean.⁴

The Lord is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart,
And saveth such as be of a contrite spirit.⁵

Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy loving-kindness:

According to the multitude of thy tender mercies blot out my transgressions.

Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity,
And cleanse me from my sin.

For I acknowledge my transgressions:

And my sin is ever before me.

Against thee, thee only, have I sinned,
And done that which is evil in thy sight:

¹Ezek. 33: 10-16.
²Ezek. 18: 30-32.

³1 Sam. 2: 25.
⁴Lev. 16: 30 (OA).

⁵Ps. 34: 18.

That thou mayest be justified when thou speakest,
And be clear when thou judgest.

Behold, I was shapen in iniquity;
And in sin did my mother conceive me.
Behold, thou desirest truth in the inward parts:
And in the hidden part thou shalt make me to know
wisdom.

Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean:
Wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.
Make me to hear joy and gladness;
That the bones which thou hast broken may rejoice.
Hide thy face from my sins,
And blot out all mine iniquities.

Create in me a clean heart, O God,
And renew a right spirit within me.
Cast me not away from thy presence;
And take not thy holy spirit from me.
Restore unto me the joy of thy salvation:
And uphold me with a free spirit.

Then will I teach transgressors thy ways;
And sinners shall be converted unto thee.
Deliver me from bloodguiltiness, O God, thou God of
my salvation;
And my tongue shall sing aloud of thy righteousness.

O Lord, open thou my lips;
And my mouth shall shew forth thy praise.
For thou delightest not in sacrifice; else would I give it:
Thou hast no pleasure in burnt offering.
The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit:
A broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not
despise.¹

My heart is ready, O God, my heart is ready.²

With the merciful thou wilt shew thyself merciful.³

¹Ps. 51: 1-17.

²Ps. 57: 7 (A).

³2 Sam. 22: 26.